



Marine Circular Nr. 05/ 2024, 25/11/2024

Subject: “GMDSS Operating Guidance for Ships in Distress Situations”

Ref.: IMO MSC.1/Circ. 1656, 28 November 2022 (This circular was reissued on 14 November 2024 to apply an editorial correction to the diagram in the annex.)

To: Shipowners/Operators, Legal Representatives of G-B I.S.R. flagged Vessels, Deputy Registrars Authorized Offices, Recognized Organizations (ROs) and Seafarers on board G-B flagged vessels.

Summary: The purpose of this Marine Circular is to provide operational guidance for vessels registered under the Guinea-Bissau flag regarding the use of Global Maritime Distress and Safety System (GMDSS) in emergency situations. This guidance aligns with IMO MSC.1/Circ.1656, emphasizing the importance of efficient radiocommunication procedures in life-threatening situations, in line with the Safety of Life at Sea (SOLAS) Convention Chapter IV.

1. Scope of Application:

1.1. This Circular applies to all Guinea-Bissau flagged vessels equipped with GMDSS systems. Ship operators, captains, and crew are urged to comply with the guidelines outlined herein, which are based to the relevant IMO Circular (MSC.1/Circ. 1656), to ensure the effective use of GMDSS in distress situations.

2. Key Operational Guidelines:

2.1. Initial Assessment and Communication: Upon identifying a potential distress scenario, vessel operators must evaluate the urgency and immediately utilize the appropriate GMDSS frequencies to establish contact with nearby vessels and Rescue Coordination Centers (RCCs).

2.2. If the vessel is at imminent risk of sinking or requires abandonment, EPIRB (Emergency Position-Indicating Radio Beacon) and SART (Search and Rescue Transponder) equipment must be activated and kept active as per the guidance.

3. Priority Distress Frequencies: All crew should be familiar with distress frequencies, including VHF Channel 70, MF 2187.5 kHz, and additional HF channels, as specified in the attached IMO guidance. These frequencies are critical for alerting RCCs and vessels within range.

4. Use of Survival Craft Equipment: When embarking on survival crafts, ensure VHF radios, SARTs, and EPIRBs are available and operable. EPIRBs should be float-free and activate automatically if not taken aboard the survival craft.

5. Communication and Support: Continuous communication efforts must be maintained with RCCs and nearby vessels. The Guinea-Bissau International Ships Registry is committed to providing operational support, as needed, to assist in the implementation of these guidelines.

6. Use of GMDSS Distress Frequencies by Maritime Operators

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6.1 The Guinea-Bissau International Ships Registry (G-B I.S.R.) reminds all operators of registered vessels of their obligation to maintain continuous watch on designated GMDSS distress frequencies, in accordance with IMO and ITU regulations. These frequencies include VHF Channel 70 (156.525 MHz) for Digital Selective Calling (DSC) within coastal areas, MF 2187.5 kHz for DSC in medium-range communications, and at least one HF DSC frequency (e.g., 4207.5 kHz, 6312 kHz) for long-distance operations. Ships must be equipped with properly certified GMDSS radio equipment to transmit and receive DSC alerts on these frequencies, ensuring rapid notification of distress situations and effective coordination with Rescue Coordination Centers (RCCs). Operators are advised to conduct regular equipment tests to ensure readiness and compliance.

6.2. Following a distress alert on DSC frequencies, vessels must shift communication to designated radiotelephony or Narrow Band Direct Printing (NBDP) working channels as instructed by the RCC. Operators must ensure radio operators are adequately trained and maintain familiarity with GMDSS procedures to minimize response times. Non-compliance with these requirements will be treated as a serious breach of international obligations and subject to administrative sanctions under the relevant G-B I.S.R. regulations.

7. Registry Support and Stakeholder Engagement:

7.1. The Guinea-Bissau International Ships Registry provides ongoing support to facilitate the effective application of this operational guidance. For further assistance or clarification on implementing these procedures, stakeholders are encouraged to contact the Registry's technical support team, as per below contact details.

8. Contact Information

8.1 For further assistance, the competent G-B I.S.R. Department can be reached at: G-B I.S.R – Operation Department (Email: ops@gbi-lb.org, Tel.: +30 210 4537950, +30 210 4537194).

9. Effective Date and Compliance

9.1 The provisions of the current Marine Circular have immediate effect as per the day of issuance.

10. Inquiries

10.1. Any inquiries relating to this Marine Circular may be addressed to the G-B I.S.R – Operation Department (Email: ops@gbi-lb.org, Tel.: +30 210 4537950, +30 210 4537194)

For the Guinea-Bissau International Ships Registry

Authorized Signatory:

Office of the General Ships Registrar

Attached in Electronic Form

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